

# PLANET STORIES

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— THE UNIVERSE OF FUTURE CENTURIES

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by LEIGH BRACKETT

## MUTINY ABOARD THE "TERRA"

by ROSS ROCKLYNNE

## INVADERS OF THE FORBIDDEN MOON

A NOVEL OF SPACE-  
ADVENTURE

by

RAYMOND Z.  
GALLUN

20c



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\*\*\* START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE BALLAD  
OF BLASTER BILL \*\*\*

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# **The Ballad of Blaster Bill**

**By Nelson S. Bond**

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When you're hurtling 'round the Sun  
On the perihelion run  
Through the asteroids from Jupiter to Mars,  
You may chance to see a light  
In the everlasting night,  
An unwinking beacon, sister to the stars.

Then each member of the crew  
From the lowest wiper to  
The Skipper on the bridge, a moment will

Drop all work and gravely, mute,  
Raise his arm in full salute  
To the final resting place of Blaster Bill.

Afterward, if you are not  
Just a nosey rankey-pot, [\[1\]](#)  
And the thing that ticks within you isn't stone,  
You may learn from spacemens' lips  
Tales of ancient days and ships,  
And why Bill the Blaster lies there all alone.

## II

Surly Jonathan McNeer  
Was the Master Engineer  
On the wallowing old freighter, *Dotty Sue*.  
He was gruff, uncouth, unclean,  
And his language was obscene,  
But a better grease-pot never sheared the blue.

He had nerves of tempered steel,  
And without a squawk or squeal  
He would plot a course to Hades for a thrill;  
But his temper was like fire  
And the man who drew his ire,  
Who tried his patience most, was—Blaster Bill.

Bill the Blaster was a lazy,  
Good-for-nothing (some said crazy),  
Guy who didn't have a gray cell in his head.  
He had muscle in his shoulders,  
And his forearms were like boulders,  
But his cranium and can were filled with lead.

Without ever even trying  
He could make McNeer start crying  
Down the wrath of Baal upon his hapless dome.  
He and awkwardness were cousins,

He broke things by scores and dozens  
Just one look at him and tubes sang, "Ohm, sweet Ohm!"

On the *Dotty Sue*, his duty  
Was to keep all tutti-frutti  
The rocket-blasts, the motors and the rest  
Of the intricate equipment  
Which insures a speedy shipment  
To the planets that are buttons on Sol's vest.

But McNeer's deserved objection  
Was—Bill practiced vivisection  
Every time he placed his thumbs (which numbered five)  
On a section of machinery.  
"He'd be better in a beanery!"  
Was McNeer's complaint. "I'll skin the guy alive!"

"Now, there, Jonathan!" the Skipper  
Used to say, "Don't be a yipper.  
I'm sure Bill does the best he can." But grief  
Etched gray, fretful lines and horrid  
On McNeer's space-weathered forehead.  
"The best is none too good!" complained the Chief.

### III

Two months out of Io City  
Everything was running pretty,  
The asteroids were thirty hours away,  
When McNeer, to whom perfection  
Was a sort of predilection,  
Said, "Bill, we'll take the hypos down today."

Well, the hypatomic motors  
Are the energy-plus rotors  
That control a spaceship's motion in the void.  
When the ship is once free-wheeling  
'Neath the vast celestial ceiling,

Then's the time to clean the grit with which they're cloyed.

So Bill said, "Yup. Okey-dokey!"  
And with movements slow and pokey  
Dismounted Number one and got to work.  
"Do a perfect job, you *globaar*!<sup>[2]</sup>  
Or I'll crown you with a crow-bar!"  
Warned McNeer—and then he vanished with a smirk.

It was some two hours later  
As, upon his "sweet pertater"  
The Chief Engineer was tootling *Venus Nell*,  
That the Second Mate, half witless,  
Out of breath and frightened spitless,  
Burst in crying, "Chief, we're on our way to hell!"

"What, already?" drawled McNeer  
But the mate, pale green with fear,  
Bawled, "Go get the hypos working, without fail!  
And go do it on the double,  
'Cause we're in a peck of trouble!  
A rogue asteroid is riding on our tail!"

#### IV

Now, in case you don't remember,  
A "rogue asteroid's" a member  
Of the minor planet group that's slipped its cogs.  
Wrenched by gravitational forces,  
It careens about its courses  
In an orbit not computable by logs.

Tons on tons of granite, metaled,  
By the tug of Jove unsettled,  
Weaving in, about, below its normal belt;  
Is it any wonder why a  
Spaceman fears this mad pariah?  
Dreads the moment when its power may be felt?

With a single, sharp, explosive  
Word that acted as corrosive  
On the mate's embarrassed eardrums, raced McNeer  
To the engine-room where, peaceful,  
Happy, busy, very grease-full,  
Labored Blaster Bill, with grins from ear to ear.

"Bill!" McNeer cried, voice all blurry,  
"Get that hypo in a hurry—"  
Then his order strangled as he stared, aghast.  
"What is this?" he faltered weakly,  
"What is this?" And Bill, quite meekly,  
Said, "I thought I'd melt it down for a recast!"

His imagination racing  
The Chief gazed upon the casing  
Of the hypatomic motor Number Three,  
Now a pool of molten metal  
Bubbling gently in a kettle.  
"Goddlemighty!" yelled McNeer. "This thing can't be!"

Bill asked, "Why the mad commotion?"  
Then they glimpsed a sudden motion  
And the Skipper's face was in the televiser.  
"Got the motors fixed, McNeer?"  
And the Chief said, low and clear,  
"No. Does someone know a prayer amongst you guys?"

"Why?" the Skipper roared, distraught;  
The Chief let him have it straight.  
"The hypatomic's melted into wax!  
But before that rogue gets near,  
I've a twelve pound hammer here  
To warp across my blaster's parallax!"

"Wait!" the Captain cried, "Not yet!  
We must cover every bet.  
I'm commander of this freighter while she rolls.

We must somehow make a turn,  
Shake that damn rogue off our stern.  
Suppose you try the manual controls?"

McNeer sadly shook his head  
As he saw the rusty red  
Of the long neglected manuals, but yelled,  
"Hop to it, Bill, you dope!  
It's our last and only hope—"   
And then he stopped and gulped, "Well, I'll be helled!"

With his back arched neck to heel,  
Bill was straining at the wheel;  
The year-old rust was breaking off in flakes.  
McNeer's eyes lit with joy,  
He shouted, "Bill, my boy!  
See, there, lad? She gives! She shakes!"

And true enough, the screw  
Of the gallant *Dotty Sue*  
Was turning 'neath the blaster's mighty brawn.  
The C. E.'s voice was thunder,  
"We're getting out from under!  
Just hold 'er, Bill; the danger will be gone!"

A moment, still as death,  
While Bill the Blaster's breath  
Rasped through the rocking room in tortured sobs,  
Then from the bridge rang out  
The Skipper's warning shout,  
"Too late! Abandon ship, Chief! Don your lobs!"

McNeer said, "Too bad, Bill,  
Just hold 'er there until  
I get the lobs, and then we'll pull our freight."  
With firm, untrembling hands  
He took down from their stands  
Two spacesuits, worn and old and out of date.

But Bill the Blaster stood  
As motionless as wood;  
His arms like knotted oak in cords of strain.  
He slowly shook his head  
And to the Chief he said,  
"If all break ship, we'll not see Earth again."

"I know—" began McNeer,  
But Bill roared out, "Stand clear!"  
His arms upon the wheel were like a vise.  
"Break ship and wait outside,  
I'll make this baby ride!  
I'll hold 'er till the devil skates on ice!"

Then in the visiplat  
Appeared the Second Mate,  
"All out below? Did you break ship, McNeer?"  
McNeer said, "Right away!  
Come on, Bill, don't delay!"  
But Bill the Blaster panted, "Chief, stand clear!"

"You fool, you're courting death!"  
Bill answered, "Save your breath,"  
And grinned, "You'll need that oxygen outside!"  
And stood like frozen steel  
Beside that bucking wheel,  
McNeer, reluctant, hovered at his side....

Till Bill cried, "You damn fool!"  
And grabbed a handy tool  
And slashed it 'cross his headpiece like a mace.  
There came a crashing roar,  
McNeer knew nothing more  
Until he woke to find himself in space.

## V

About him, staff and crew

Of the ill-starred *Dotty Sue*  
Were huddled, bitter, grim, but unafraid.  
A quarter mile away  
The last scene of the fray  
Tween Man and Asteroid was being played.

Her stern jets flaming white  
Against the endless night  
The bobbing ship was fighting, bolt and nail,  
To curve from underneath  
Those looming tons of death  
That poised above her like a cosmic flail.

McNeer cried, "No, Bill! No!"  
And then his audio  
Clacked with the Skipper's thin, metallic voice,  
"There's nothing we can do  
But hope he pulls her through.  
He made his choice, McNeer; a hero's choice."

As they watched tensely, all,  
The spaceship seemed to crawl  
An inch, a foot, a yard, another yard....  
Meanwhile, the massive rock  
Raced blindly toward the shock  
With vast, colossal, cosmic disregard.

And nearer yet they drew,  
To their strange *rendezvous*  
In space; Fate's balance hovered fine and thin.  
And then, "The Lord be praised!"  
The crew a paeon raised;  
McNeer's white lips cracked in a nerveless grin.

Imponderable mass  
And spaceship seemed to pass  
Each other with a hair 'twixt hull and face;  
But then, as every voice

Roused in a loud rejoice,  
A single boulder slashed through empty space—

The spaceship buckled, bent;  
A gaping, white-fanged rent  
Split stern plates, and McNeer's voice cracked with fear.  
"Board ship, all hands!" he cried!  
"Bill's dying there inside!"  
The wan sun watched the killer disappear.

McNeer was first to kneel  
Beside the shattered wheel  
And Bill's pale, silent figure; gray with grief  
He cried, "He's breathing yet!  
Here, Skipper! Help me get—"  
But Bill said, "No—don't try to lift me, Chief."

"I look all right on top  
But ... better get ... a mop....  
My underneath part's not so good...." A chill  
Ran through his broken frame,  
But, to the last ditch game,  
"I held 'er to 'er course—" said Blaster Bill.

## VI

So—hurtling 'round the Sun  
On the perihelion run  
Through the asteroids from Jupiter to Mars,  
You may chance to see a light  
In the everlasting night,  
An unwinking beacon, sister to the stars.

And then, if you are not  
A lousy *rankey-pot*,  
With the instincts of the back end of a horse,  
You'll stand a moment, mute,  
Arm raised in full salute

To Blaster Bill—who held 'er to 'er course.

[1] *rankey-pot*—Earthlubber; from the Venusian "*renqui-pth*"

[2] *globaar*—shiftless person; Ionian term of reproach

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BLASTER BILL \*\*\*

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